

The Sermon on the Mount: The Kingdom and the Upside-Down Life

The King describes the country, and almost everything He says is the reverse of what we assumed.

Text. Matthew 5 to 7

Good for. Disciples ready to be told what the kingdom actually costs and gives

The arc. Jesus sits down and describes life under His reign, and the description overturns our scorecards from the first beatitude to the last warning. The thread is a righteousness that exceeds the surface and reaches the heart, lived before a Father who sees in secret.

1. Blessed Are the Poor in Spirit

Matthew 5:1-12

Big idea. The kingdom belongs to the empty, the mourning, and the meek, which reverses every list the world keeps.

Aim. To dismantle the hearer's idea of who is doing well before God.

Notes

2. Salt, Light, and the Law Fulfilled

Matthew 5:13-20

Big idea. Disciples are a visible city and a preserving salt, and Christ has come not to abolish the law but to fill it full.

Aim. To raise the hearer's sense of what righteousness was always meant to be.

Notes

3. Anger, Lust, and the Heart of the Law

Matthew 5:21-37

Big idea. The King traces murder back to contempt and adultery back to the look, because the law was always aimed at the heart.

Aim. To stop the hearer from grading themselves by the acts they have avoided.

Notes

4. Love Your Enemies

Matthew 5:38-48

Big idea. Children of the Father love those who hate them, reflecting a God who sends rain on the just and the unjust alike.

Aim. To press the hearer toward a love that has no natural explanation.

Notes

5. Secret Righteousness

Matthew 6:1-18

Big idea. Giving, prayer, and fasting are for the Father who sees in secret, not for the audience that pays in applause.

Aim. To purge the hearer's obedience of its hunger to be seen.

Notes

6. Treasure and Anxiety

Matthew 6:19-34

Big idea. Where the treasure is the heart follows, and the Father who feeds the birds frees His children from anxious striving.

Aim. To relocate the hearer's security from their accounts to their Father.

Notes

7. Judging, Asking, and the Golden Rule

Matthew 7:1-12

Big idea. Disciples deal first with their own log, ask a good Father for good gifts, and treat others as they long to be treated.

Aim. To turn the hearer's critical eye inward and their generosity outward.

Notes

8. Two Ways, Two Trees, Two Builders

Matthew 7:13-29

Big idea. The sermon ends at a fork, and only the one who hears these words and does them is building on rock.

Aim. To bring the hearer to the moment of decision the whole sermon was driving toward.

Notes

HOW TO USE THIS SERIES

These are starting points, not scripts. Each series gives you the arc, the divisions, and a working aim for every sermon, but the breakdown here is scaffolding you will take down once the text has done its own work in you. Read the whole book before you preach the first week of it. Let the passage divisions teach you where the seams actually are.

The text sets the agenda. Not the felt needs you arrived with, not the outline that looks clean on a slide, not the application you already know you want to land. Sit under the passage long enough for it to surprise you, and then preach what it says rather than what you planned. A big idea you did not have to fight for is usually one the text did not give you.